

STUDENT WORKBOOK

Presentation Skills

A colourful, practical workbook to help you plan, design, deliver and improve powerful presentations.

Clear Structure

Engaging Slides

Confident Delivery

PLAN the message

DESIGN the story

DELIVER with confidence

CONNECT with people

1

Complete Concepts

2

Practice Activities

3

Self-Checks

“

A powerful presentation is not a performance of memory. It is a transfer of understanding.

Use this workbook: during classroom learning, placement preparation, research presentations, orientation programmes and communication-skills practice.

01 The Big Idea

A good presentation is not about speaking perfect English. It is about helping the audience understand, remember and trust your message.

C

Clear Idea

Know exactly what you want to say.

S

Simple Structure

Guide people step by step.

D

Confident Delivery

Use voice and body naturally.

A

Audience Connection

Make the message relevant.

Common presentation myths

- ✗ I need advanced vocabulary.
- ✗ I must remove all nervousness.
- ✗ I should memorise every sentence.
- ✗ More information means a better presentation.

What actually works

- ✓ Use simple, accurate language.
- ✓ Prepare and manage nervousness.
- ✓ Remember the flow, not a script.
- ✓ Select only what helps the purpose.

Remember this: "My job is not to impress the audience with complexity. My job is to make the audience say: Now I understand."

What you will learn

By the end of this workbook, you should be able to plan a clear message, organise ideas, design simple slides, speak with better voice and posture, handle nervousness, manage Q&A and use feedback to improve.

The 7 Pillars of a Strong Presentation

Pillar 1

Know the Audience

Understand who they are, what they know and what they need.

Pillar 2

One Main Message

Decide the single idea the audience should remember.

Pillar 3

Simple Structure

Create a logical journey from opening to conclusion.

Pillar 4

Strong Opening

Earn attention in the first 20-30 seconds.

Pillar 5

Visual Slides

Use slides as support, not as a full written report.

Pillar 6

Effective Delivery

Control voice, pace, posture, eye contact and gestures.

Pillar 7

Practice and Feedback

Confidence comes from repeated practice, reflection and focused feedback - not from last-minute memorisation.

How to use these pillars: Pick one presentation you have seen. Identify one weak element, imagine how you would improve it, and explain what would change for the audience.

Quick reflection question

Think about the best presentation you have ever watched. What made it effective - the content, story, visuals, speaker or audience connection?

Ask before making slides

Question	Why it matters
Who are they?	Classmates, teachers, judges, clients or experts?
What do they know?	Beginner, intermediate or technical?
What do they need?	Information, evidence, a decision or motivation?
What should they remember?	The one final takeaway.

Audience Lens

Knowledge How much background is needed?

Interest Why should they care?

Language What words will they understand?

Expectation What do they expect to receive?

Action What should they do afterwards?

SPEAKER-CENTRED

"I want to show everything I know about artificial intelligence."

AUDIENCE-CENTRED

"I want beginners to understand one practical way AI can improve hospital safety."

"My presentation is not for me. It is for the audience."

Try it - Same topic, different audience

Choose one topic, such as "cybersecurity". Explain it to: (1) a 10-year-old child, (2) a college professor, and (3) a company manager. Notice how your examples, vocabulary and level of detail must change.

Pillar 2: One Main Message

Core rule: A presentation can contain many points, but it should communicate one central message.

TOO BROAD

"Today I will discuss AI, machine learning, deep learning, robots, datasets, ethics, applications and future work."

FOCUSED

"Today I will show how AI helps a robot deliver medicine safely in a hospital room."

The One-Sentence Test

"After my presentation, the audience should remember that _____."

If the blank cannot be completed clearly, the presentation is not focused enough.

Delete

Remove information that does not support the main point.

Combine

Merge repeated ideas into one stronger message.

Emphasise

Repeat the takeaway in the opening, body and conclusion.

Message Map

Main Message



Reason 1



Evidence

Main Message



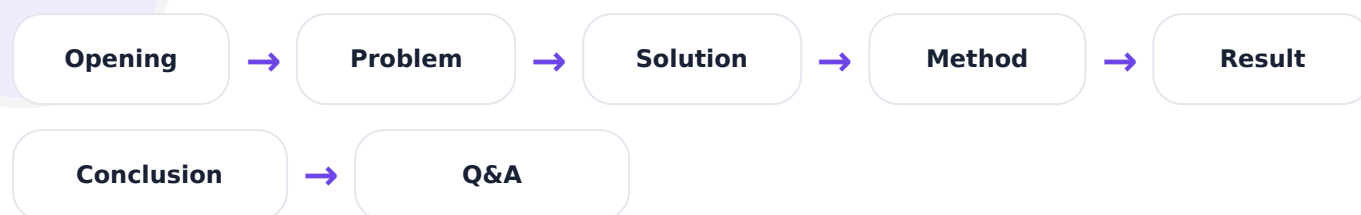
Reason 2



Example

Editing rule: Do not ask, "What else can I add?" Ask, "What can I remove without weakening the message?"

Pillar 3: Use a Simple Structure



Part	Purpose	Useful phrase
Opening	Get attention	"Imagine a robot helping a nurse..."
Problem	Explain why it matters	"The current process creates..."
Solution	Introduce your idea	"Our proposed system..."
Method	Explain how it works	"The process has four steps..."
Result	Provide proof	"The experiment shows..."
Conclusion	Reinforce takeaway	"The main message is..."
Q&A	Invite interaction	"I would be happy to take questions."

WEAK FLOW

Algorithm → dataset → model → technical detail → problem

AUDIENCE FLOW

Problem → importance → idea → method → evidence → impact

Transition phrases: "Now that we understand the problem...", "This leads to our proposed solution...", "Let us look at the results...", "The key takeaway is..."

Pillar 4: Start Strong

**The first 20-30 seconds have one job:
Give the audience a reason to listen.**

1. Situation

"Imagine you have only five minutes to convince people that your project matters."

2. Question

"Have you ever known the answer but still felt nervous while presenting?"

3. Problem

"Many students lose marks not because the idea is weak, but because the explanation is unclear."

4. Short Story

"A student had excellent research, but nobody understood the result because every slide was crowded."

COMMON

"Good morning everyone. Today my topic is presentation skills."

STRONGER

"What makes an audience stop listening - even when the topic is important?"

Opening formula

Hook

+

Relevance

+

Roadmap

Example: "Most students fear presentations. Today I will show three practical ways to feel more prepared and speak more clearly."

Avoid: long apologies, reading the title slide, unrelated jokes, dictionary definitions and exaggerated claims.

Slides are support for the speaker - not the speaker's full script.

One Slide

One main idea or takeaway.

Message Title

The title should state the point, not just the topic.

Less Text

Use keywords, labels and short statements.

Useful Visuals

Use diagrams, charts, images and process flows.

Highlight

Direct attention with contrast, size or arrows.

Consistency

Keep fonts, spacing and colours predictable.

PARAGRAPH SLIDE

Our project develops a robot that identifies medicine, picks it up, navigates through the room, avoids obstacles and places the medicine safely using computer vision, deep learning, path planning and manipulation.

VISUAL SLIDE

Robot delivers medicine in 4 steps

Detect → Pick → Navigate → Place

Good slide title

"Noise reduced command accuracy by 40%."

Weak slide title

"Experimental Results"

Accessibility: use readable font sizes, strong contrast, simple charts and meaningful labels. Never depend only on colour to explain meaning.

Pillar 6: Delivery That Feels Confident

Voice

Speak clearly and vary emphasis.

Pace

Slow down and pause after key ideas.

Eye Contact

Look at people, not only the screen.

Posture

Stand balanced, open and relaxed.

Gestures

Use hands naturally to explain meaning.

Movement

Move with purpose, not continuously.

Pause and Emphasis Drill

Sentence: "This result is important because it shows our system works in real time."

Better delivery: "This result is important... because it shows our system works in real time."

Try the sentence three ways: too fast, too flat, and then with pauses and emphasis. Notice which version is easiest to understand.

DISTRACTING

- ✗ Turning back to the audience
- ✗ Rocking or pacing continuously
- ✗ Hands hidden throughout
- ✗ Speaking in one flat tone

EFFECTIVE

- ✓ Face the audience
- ✓ Pause before key points
- ✓ Use natural gestures
- ✓ Change tone for meaning

Important myth: Body language supports communication, but it does not replace clear words and good content. The idea that nearly all communication is non-verbal is misleading.

09 Managing Nervousness

Nervousness is not failure. It is your body preparing to perform.

Problem	Practical response
Shaky voice	Take one slow breath before the first sentence.
Speaking too fast	Pause after every slide title and major point.
Forgetting lines	Remember keywords and flow, not full sentences.
Avoiding eye contact	Start with one friendly face, then scan gradually.
Shaking hands	Hold the clicker lightly or rest hands naturally.
Mind goes blank	Pause, breathe and say: "Let me explain that another way."

Before

Rehearse the opening, check technology and arrive early.

During

Focus on helping the audience, not judging yourself.

After

Write one success and one improvement - not ten criticisms.

30-second reset routine

Feet grounded



Slow exhale



Relax shoulders



First line

Remember: "Nervousness usually feels much bigger inside you than it appears to the audience. Preparation gives that energy a direction."

10 Pillar 7: Practice and Feedback

Stage 1

Fix the structure. Read silently and remove unnecessary material.

Stage 2

Speak aloud. Notice sentences that feel too long or unnatural.

Stage 3

Record yourself. Check pace, clarity, posture and filler words.

Stage 4

Present to one person. Ask what was clear and confusing.

Stage 5

Present to a small group. Test timing and Q&A.

Stage 6

Final rehearsal. Practise with the actual slides and equipment.

Useful feedback

"Your example made the idea clear. Pause longer before the result slide."

Weak feedback

"It was good" or "Be more confident" without saying how.

3-2-1 Peer Feedback

3

Three strengths

2

Two improvements

1

One key takeaway

Feedback rule: Make feedback specific, observable and actionable. Comment on what the speaker did, not on the speaker's personality.

11 The P.R.E.S.E.N.T. Formula

A memorable planning checklist you can use before every presentation.

P	Purpose	Why am I presenting? What should this presentation achieve?
R	Receiver	Who is the audience and what do they already know?
E	Evidence	What examples, data or proof support my message?
S	Structure	Is the journey logical from opening to conclusion?
E	Engagement	How will I gain and maintain attention?
N	Natural	Do I sound like myself rather than a memorised robot?
T	Takeaway	What one sentence should the audience remember?

Fast self-check: Rate yourself from 1 to 5 for each letter. Your lowest score becomes your first priority for improvement.

Purpose gives direction. Audience gives relevance. Structure gives clarity. Practice gives confidence.

Your 90-Minute Presentation Practice Plan

Use this guided session alone, with a partner or as part of a classroom workshop.

0-10

Diagnose: Write what makes a presentation boring. Compare one crowded slide with one simple slide.

10-25

Build your structure: Plan Opening - Problem - Solution - Method - Result - Conclusion - Q&A.

25-40

Redesign one slide: Keep one idea, write a message title, remove extra text and add one useful visual.

40-55

Delivery drill: Practise pace, pauses, emphasis, posture and eye contact.

55-70

Prepare for nerves: Try slow breathing, keyword notes and recovery phrases for moments when your mind goes blank.

70-85

Present: Give a one-minute mini-presentation and collect 3-2-1 feedback.

85-90

Reflect: Write one specific action you will use in your next presentation.

One-minute presentation format

10

Opening

30

Main idea

10

Example

10

Conclusion

Choose a mini-topic: My favourite app, a daily-life problem, why students should learn AI, a research idea, or a product I want to design.

Presentation Practice Challenges

1. Bad Slide Surgery

Take a crowded slide. Reduce the text, improve the title, add a useful visual and highlight one key point.

2. 30-Second Opening

Prepare only your opening. Use a question, short story, problem or real-life situation.

3. Explain to a Child

Explain a technical idea to a 10-year-old using simple words and one clear analogy.

4. No-Slide Challenge

Present for one minute without slides. This tests whether your message is clear by itself.

5. Pause Practice

Mark pauses and emphasis on a short script. Deliver it twice and compare the difference.

6. Record and Review

Record yourself. Check pace, eye contact, posture, filler words, clarity and timing.

Observation checklist for recorded practice

- ✓ Is the main message clear?
- ✓ Do I speak too quickly?
- ✓ Do I explain visuals?
- ✓ Do I look at the audience?
- ✓ Are gestures natural?
- ✓ Do I finish on time?

Confidence path: practise alone -> with a partner -> in a small group -> in front of the full class.

14 How to Handle Q&A

A good answer begins with good listening.

The A.R.E.A. Method

A

Acknowledge

"That is a useful question."

R

Repeat

Clarify what the person is asking.

E

Explain

Give a direct, relevant answer.

A

Add / Close

Connect back to the main message.

Example

Question: Why did you choose this model?

Answer: "You are asking why we selected this model rather than a larger one. We chose it because it is faster and suitable for real-time use. In future work, we will compare it with additional models."

When you know

Answer in one clear sentence first, then add evidence or explanation.

When you do not know

"We have not tested that yet. It is a valuable direction for future work."

Never: interrupt the question, become defensive, invent an answer, or speak for two minutes before answering the actual question.

Pause for two seconds before answering. A calm pause looks thoughtful and gives you time to organise your response.

For engineering, AI, robotics and academic project presentations.

1. Motivation

Why does the problem matter?

2. Gap

What is missing in existing work?

3. Contribution

What is your new idea?

4. Method

How does the system work?

5. Evidence

Dataset, experiment and results.

6. Meaning

What do the results prove?

Slide	Purpose
Title	State the project clearly.
Motivation / Problem	Explain human or scientific importance.
Related Work / Gap	Show what exists and what is missing.
Proposed Method	Explain the architecture or process visually.
Experiment	Describe data, setup, baselines and metrics.
Results	Highlight the most important comparison.
Limitations	Be honest about what is not solved.
Conclusion / Future Work	Reinforce contribution and next step.

Golden rule: Do not show complexity first. Show the problem first, then reveal technical detail only when the audience understands why it is needed.

Criteria	Excellent	Good	Needs Improvement
Content	Clear, accurate and meaningful	Mostly clear	Confusing or incomplete
Structure	Strong logical flow	Some clear organisation	Random or difficult to follow
Slides	Visual, simple and readable	Generally effective	Text-heavy or distracting
Voice	Clear, confident and well-paced	Understandable	Too fast, low or unclear
Eye Contact	Connects with the audience	Looks up sometimes	Reads mainly from slides
Body Language	Natural and purposeful	Slightly stiff	Distracting or closed
Timing	Finishes comfortably on time	Slightly over/under	Poor time control
Q&A	Answers directly and honestly	Partial answers	Avoids or becomes confused

Self-assessment scoring

Excellent = 4, Good = 3, Developing = 2, Beginning = 1. Total possible score: 32.

Choose one improvement target

Select only one category to improve in your next presentation. A focused target is easier to practise and measure.

Feedback sentence starters

- ✓ "The clearest part was..."
- ✓ "I understood your main point when..."
- ✓ "One place to pause or simplify is..."
- ✓ "Your next improvement could be..."

MISTAKE**"Today my topic is..."**

Better: Open with a question, problem, situation or short story.

MISTAKE**Reading every word**

Better: Put keywords on the slide and explanations in your voice.

MISTAKE**Too much information**

Better: Select only what supports the main message.

MISTAKE**Memorising a full script**

Better: Memorise the flow, opening and conclusion.

MISTAKE**Ending with "That's all"**

Better: Repeat the takeaway and invite questions.

MISTAKE**Ignoring time**

Better: Practise with a timer and plan what to cut.

Strong conclusion formula

Restate message



Show significance



Memorable final line

"The main message is simple: good presentations are built on clear thinking, purposeful structure and deliberate practice."

Conclusion rule: Do not introduce new information. Help the audience organise and remember what they have already heard.

Your presentation mindset

Presentation skill is not perfect English or perfect performance. It is the ability to explain an idea clearly so the audience understands and remembers it. Simple language becomes powerful when your structure is clear, your slides are focused and your delivery is prepared.

Before

- ✓ Know the audience
- ✓ Choose one message
- ✓ Build a clear flow
- ✓ Practise aloud
- ✓ Check timing

During

- ✓ Start strongly
- ✓ Speak slowly
- ✓ Pause often
- ✓ Look at people
- ✓ Explain visuals

Q&A

- ✓ Listen fully
- ✓ Clarify the question
- ✓ Answer directly
- ✓ Be honest if unsure
- ✓ Connect back

A strong presentation is not about being perfect. It is about being clear, prepared and connected with the audience.

Your final reflection

Complete these three sentences:

1. My strongest presentation skill is _____.
2. My next improvement will be _____.
3. In my next presentation, I will _____.

Evidence-Informed Reference List

Useful sources for deeper learning and further practice.

Harvard Division of Continuing Education. Tips for improving public speaking skills. professional.dce.harvard.edu

Stanford Medicine. Oral presentation guidance. med.stanford.edu/ppop/oralpresentation.html

MIT Communication Lab. Slideshow and slide-design guidance. mitcommmlab.mit.edu

Purdue Online Writing Lab. Public speaking and presentation guidance. owl.purdue.edu

Harvard Business Review. How to Give a Killer Presentation. hbr.org

Toastmasters International. Public speaking tips and practice resources. toastmasters.org

AAC&U. Oral Communication VALUE Rubric. aacu.org/value-rubrics

Carnegie Mellon University. Presentation and speaking assessment resources. cmu.edu/teaching

Richard E. Mayer. Multimedia learning principles: coherence, signalling, redundancy and contiguity.

Mehrabian communication research. Frequently misapplied outside its original context of feelings and attitudes.

Research on public-speaking anxiety. Shows that anxiety is common and that self-perception may be harsher than observer ratings.

Peer-evaluation and rubric research. Supports clear criteria and actionable feedback for presentation improvement.

How to keep improving

Combine explanation, demonstration, guided practice, feedback and repetition. You improve fastest when you apply one concept immediately and track one specific change at a time.

The final message

You do not need to become a performer. You need to become a clear, thoughtful communicator.